

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Math	Advanced Math	Nonlinear equations in one variable and systems of equations in two variables	Hard

Question

$$x^2 - 2x - 9 = 0$$

One solution to the given equation can be written as $1 + \sqrt{k}$, where k is a constant. What is the value of k ?

Answer

- A. 8
- B. 10
- C. 20
- D. 40

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is correct. Adding 9 to each side of the given equation yields $x^2 - 2x = 9$. To complete the square, adding 1 to each side of this equation yields $x^2 - 2x + 1 = 9 + 1$, or $(x - 1)^2 = 10$. Taking the square root of each side of this equation yields $x - 1 = \pm\sqrt{10}$. Adding 1 to each side of this equation yields $x = 1 \pm \sqrt{10}$. Since it's given that one of the solutions to the equation can be written as $1 + \sqrt{k}$, the value of k must be 10.

Alternate approach: It's given that $1 + \sqrt{k}$ is a solution to the given equation. It follows that $x = 1 + \sqrt{k}$. Substituting $1 + \sqrt{k}$ for x in the given equation yields $(1 + \sqrt{k})^2 - 2(1 + \sqrt{k}) - 9 = 0$, or $(1 + \sqrt{k})(1 + \sqrt{k}) - 2(1 + \sqrt{k}) - 9 = 0$. Expanding the products on the left-hand side of this equation yields $1 + 2\sqrt{k} + k - 2 - 2\sqrt{k} - 9 = 0$, or $k - 10 = 0$. Adding 10 to each side of this equation yields $k = 10$.

Choice A is incorrect and may result from conceptual or calculation errors.

Choice C is incorrect and may result from conceptual or calculation errors.

Choice D is incorrect and may result from conceptual or calculation errors.